



Flame-throwing tanks

Flame weapons have been in use since ancient times, and were used effectively as man-portable weapons in World War I. They often had a major psychological impact—sometimes their very presence caused surrender. However, they were limited by their short range, the amount of fuel that could be carried, and their vulnerability. Some of these issues, however, could be overcome by mounting a flame-thrower on a vehicle.

ADAPTED VEHICLES

The Italian army produced a flame-throwing tankette in 1935, the L3 LI, which saw extensive service before and during the early period of World War II, as did a flame-thrower mounted on

the Russian T-26 tank. The German army mounted flame-throwers on half-tracks and on Panzer III tanks, particularly with urban operations in mind, where they could be used to clear bunkers and houses. In Britain, flame-throwers were attached to Universal Carriers to form the Wasp, or to Churchill tanks to make the Crocodile, which towed an armored trailer of fuel and could fire up to 80 one-second bursts. Flame-throwing tanks continued to be used into the 21st century.

A US Marine Corps M67 "Zippo" tank, one of 109 converted M48 Pattons, flames a village near Binh Son in the Quang Ngai Province, 1969.